

Cassandra McCaughey/ Online News Article Assignment

FIFA Scandal Ends In US Defeat!

On July 1, during the United States v. Bosnia and Herzegovina World Cup match, one of the star American players was given a red card. The referee never called the foul, though- the Bosnian coach asked him to review the footage. Folarin Balogun was taken off the field and suspended from the next game, which would be the US versus Belgium following our victory over Bosnia.

The referee's decision was *highly* controversial, not just because of its implications on the USA's chances in the next game but also because Balogun fell on the other player, and it looked to many like it wasn't intentional and therefore wasn't a foul. In speaking about the tackle, Balogun defended himself, saying, “ I think a yellow card would have been fair. Just due to it not being intentional, and also there's not many places I can place my foot in such a scenario. ”

Suspended Suspension

Shortly following the game, Trump called FIFA President Gianni Infantino to discuss Balogun's suspension. On Sunday, July 5th, FIFA officially announced it was suspending the implementation of the ban by a year, effectively taking it back. This intervention made worldwide news as something of a scandal, and other soccer organizations like the UEFA (Union of European Football Associations) and RBFA (Royal Belgian Football Association) protested the sudden change. On their official website, the UEFA released a statement about the case, condemning FIFA's decision.

We express our disbelief at such an unprecedented, incomprehensible and unjustifiable decision.

- *The Union of European Football Associations*

All For Nothing?

Despite this backlash, the full US team played in the Round of 16 match in Seattle. Balogun was played as a starter, but this didn't prevent the crushing 4-1 defeat. The round was a knockout, and so the US team was eliminated from the 2026 World Cup while Belgium advanced. In the end, the whole controversy didn't really mean anything, and all the tensions over it were resolved with the Belgian victory, until the next World Cup.

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-T.O.T.